ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Hostel and Off-Campus Living: Rent, Roommates and Realistic Costs

Choose accommodation with your eyes open and live with fewer conflicts

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Accommodation decisions affect cost, safety, study time and stress. This pack covers comparing hostel and off-campus options, inspecting a lodge before paying, understanding rent and agency fees, and managing shared living without daily conflict.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Compare hostel and off-campus options on cost, safety and study conditions.
- Inspect accommodation and verify ownership before paying.
- Budget for hidden accommodation costs.
- Set shared-living rules that prevent common conflicts.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Choose on criteria, not pressure

Accommodation is a package: rent, transport, utilities, security and study environment.

- Hostel advantages: proximity, campus security, less commuting. Disadvantages: crowding, rules and limited privacy.
- Off-campus advantages: space and flexibility. Disadvantages: transport cost, landlord risk and security variability.
- Calculate total monthly cost, not just rent.
- Consider distance to your faculty, not just to the main gate.
- Check water, power and network coverage at different times of day.
- Decide before the last week of vacation; panic raises both price and risk.

Inspect and verify

Never pay for a room you have not entered, and never pay without documentation.

1. Visit in person and inspect the room, toilet, water source and wiring.
2. Speak to current tenants about the landlord, security and interruptions.
3. Confirm ownership or the agent's authority to collect rent.
4. Read the tenancy agreement, including duration, notice and refund terms.
5. Pay through a traceable method and collect a signed receipt.
6. Photograph the room's condition at handover.

> **The too-cheap warning**
> A rent far below the area average is either misrepresented or unsafe. Inspect with a friend and never be rushed by 'another person is paying today'.

Living with others

Most roommate conflict is unspoken expectation, not malice.

- Agree on cleaning rotas, cooking, noise hours and guest rules in the first week.
- Agree on how shared bills are collected and recorded.
- Respect boundaries around food, clothes and personal items.
- Raise a problem early and privately rather than accumulating resentment.
- Secure your valuables; familiarity does not remove risk.
- Keep an emergency contact and know the nearest health facility.